

Key Outreach Contacts – Background and Connections

Lauren Middleton-Pratt – Austin Planning Director

Current Role & Responsibilities: Lauren Middleton-Pratt is the Director of the City of Austin's Planning Department (appointed 2023 after Austin split its Housing and Planning offices) ¹. In this capacity, she oversees Austin's zoning and long-range planning efforts, focusing on "*data-driven planning and inclusive community engagement*" to guide sustainable growth ². Previously an Assistant City Manager in Buda, she brings 15+ years of urban planning and development experience ³. Her department handles everything from current zoning cases (e.g. where to allow a new single-family home vs. an industrial use) to big-picture planning for Austin's future decades ⁴.

Relevant Statements on Housing & Engagement: Since taking the helm, Middleton-Pratt has stressed the importance of balancing **speed with public participation** in updating Austin's land use policies. For example, with dozens of City Council-mandated Land Development Code amendments in the pipeline, she noted that "**we want to be quick. We just don't want to be in a hurry; we don't want to be sloppy with it**" – emphasizing that code changes must be done *right* with proper community input ⁵. She has highlighted the need to communicate "*at the right cadence at the right time*" and to **meet residents where they are**, since not everyone can attend City Hall meetings or engage online ⁵. Middleton-Pratt is aware of public perceptions that staff are only heard from at formal hearings, and she has made it a priority to **get the Planning Department "more engaged in the community"** beyond required meetings ⁶. In a recent Q&A, she acknowledged the "**lack of transparency**" felt by many residents and expressed a desire to rebuild trust through proactive outreach (e.g. launching a dedicated Planning Dept. website, holding one-on-one sessions at the Permitting Center) ⁷ ⁸.

Involvement in Austin Initiatives: Middleton-Pratt has quickly become involved in major policy updates. Under her direction, planning staff advanced reforms to the **University Neighborhood Overlay (UNO)** to allow taller student housing towers, though she opted to delay the City Council vote in mid-2025 in order to "formally meet" with University of Texas leaders and address their concerns ⁹. This demonstrated her *caution in major upzoning proposals*, seeking stakeholder buy-in before moving forward. She also is laying groundwork for a **Comprehensive Plan** update – seeking funding to refresh Austin's Imagine Austin plan and integrate new district-level plans ¹⁰. Internally, Middleton-Pratt has focused on staffing up a department that had over 30% vacancies after the reorganization, as well as filling a communications role to improve public-facing outreach ¹¹ ¹².

Projects & Committees: As Planning Director, Middleton-Pratt is charged with executing Council's numerous land use changes (e.g. reducing compatibility restrictions, easing housing capacity limits) while preserving Austin's heritage and livability ². She coordinates with bodies like the Planning Commission and works alongside the Housing Department on overlapping issues (for instance, the "**HOME**" initiative to allow more units on single lots). Her approach has been to implement quick wins (several code amendments by year-end 2023) while planning for comprehensive community engagement on more

complex changes ¹³ ¹⁴ . For instance, she told Community Impact that some code fixes “will take a more comprehensive approach... a heavy lift,” requiring careful work **“to ensure only compatible housing is constructed”** and that people feel heard ¹⁴ .

Email Hook Highlights: Middleton-Pratt’s emphasis on **thoughtful, ethical use of data and technology** in planning aligns closely with this research. She has described not just planning “for what we face today... but preparing for 10, 20, 50 years from now” ¹⁵ . In outreach, she strives to **“engage everyone that will be impacted”** by meeting communities on their terms ⁵ . A personalized note might reference her quote about *not rushing and communicating at the right cadence*: **“We want to be quick... We want to make sure that we’re communicating with the community at the right cadence... meeting the needs where they are”** ⁵ . Acknowledging that perspective could segue into asking her views on using predictive tools to anticipate opposition while **maintaining transparency and trust** – issues clearly important to her.

Sources: ² ⁵ ⁷

José Roig – Former Development Services Director

Current Role & Background: José Roig is an expert in Austin’s development process, recently serving as the Director of the **Development Services Department (DSD)** (from 2023 until May 2025) ¹⁶ . In that role he oversaw all aspects of permitting and site plan review for new development in the city, drawing on 30+ years of experience in building safety and code enforcement ¹⁷ . Roig previously led the Austin Code Department (appointed director in 2020) where he was responsible for enforcing housing standards, zoning restrictions, and educating the community on code compliance ¹⁸ . He was also Austin’s first **Certified Building Official**, having worked up from inspector to Building Inspections Division Manager earlier in his career ¹⁹ . In mid-2025 Roig retired from the City of Austin and joined the International Code Council as Regional Director for Latin America, a move that underscores his standing in the field of building regulations ²⁰ ²¹ . *(He continues to reside in Austin and remains deeply familiar with the city’s development challenges.)*

Role in Austin’s Development Process: As DSD Director, Roig spearheaded efforts to streamline and modernize Austin’s notoriously complex permitting process. Under his leadership, DSD united 11 departments involved in site plan review to **“transform”** the process and improve turnaround times ²² . He oversaw a task force that identified over 40 procedural improvements – by late 2024, city workgroups had completed 26 of them, focusing on **process changes, new technology, and customer-centric solutions** to make development review more efficient ²² . These efforts paid off: initial review times for commercial site plans were cut by over 50%, dropping from ~100 days to ~32 days on average – the **fastest reviews in six years** ²³ . Roig frequently briefed City Council on these improvements, emphasizing the need to “get the process fundamentally strong” so Austin isn’t perpetually behind during development booms ²⁴ . He also had to balance staffing levels with fluctuating construction activity; in budget talks he noted plans to rely on temporary contract plan reviewers if needed, to avoid future backlogs when activity picks up ²⁵ .

Public Statements & Views: Roig has shown an openness to **innovative tools and data** to improve development services. Notably, in 2024 he launched a pilot program using **AI software to assist with building permit reviews** for single-family homes. He commented that while Austin had finally eliminated its permit backlog, **“as we get more regulations from the city, we can do things more expeditiously and more efficient”** – suggesting that automation and predictive tools could help handle the growing complexity of codes without delays ²⁶ . This mindset of *leveraging technology to maintain efficiency* is evident

in DSD's adoption of digital systems under his tenure. As Code Department director, Roig was also collaborative: "I look forward to continuing our work with internal and external stakeholders... to deliver excellent services to our vibrant and diverse community," he said upon his appointment ²⁷. He championed **education and outreach** as part of code compliance, believing that working **"with... community leaders"** would build a safer Austin through partnership as much as enforcement ²⁸ ²⁹. Consistently, Roig has presented himself as a problem-solver focused on **customer service**, whether the "customers" are developers navigating permitting or residents needing code issues addressed.

Involvement in Housing & Zoning Issues: Although Roig's purview at DSD was administrative (permitting, inspections) rather than policy-making, his work intersected with housing and zoning realities. By speeding up site plan approvals, he played a part in reducing barriers to new housing construction. He also dealt directly with **neighborhood concerns** in development: for example, implementing a **"Site Plan Lite"** program for small projects and tweaking infill subdivision rules – initiatives that sometimes required postponements and community input (as evidenced by city memos requesting more time for outreach) ³⁰ ³¹. In code enforcement, Roig tackled issues like substandard housing conditions and short-term rental enforcement, which often put him at the nexus of neighborhood quality-of-life complaints. This experience likely gave him insight into the *patterns of community opposition* to certain development behaviors. Furthermore, as the **City's building official**, he regularly balanced safety, code requirements, and practicality – skills that translate well into discussions about predictive analytics in planning (e.g. understanding how data might predict problem areas in permitting or compliance).

Email Hook Highlights: Roig's background suggests he'd respond well to an outreach that references **process improvements and technology** in planning. One could mention, for instance, **DSD's success in cutting review times by focusing on "process, technology, and customer-centric solutions"** ²² – a transformation he led – and relate it to exploring new tools for public outreach or opposition forecasting. He has explicitly noted that adopting innovations (like AI) can keep processes efficient despite added regulations ²⁶. Highlighting that **forward-thinking approach**, you might write: *"I was intrigued by your work implementing AI to streamline Austin's permit reviews – as you said, ensuring things get more 'expeditious and efficient' even with increasing regulations" ²⁶. Similarly, my project looks at using data to anticipate where community pushback might occur, so that staff can engage proactively. I'd love to get your perspective on how such predictive tools could fit into improving our development review and outreach process.*" A hook along these lines shows you recognize his legacy of innovation and invites his input on the next frontier of process improvement.

Sources: ²² ²⁷ ²⁶

Sherri Sirwaitis – Principal Planner, Current Planning Division

Role & Responsibilities: Sherri Sirwaitis is a **Principal Planner in Austin's Planning Department (Current Planning Division)** ³². In this role, she serves as a lead case manager for rezoning applications and neighborhood plan amendments that come before the **Zoning and Platting Commission (ZAP)**, Planning Commission, and City Council. Sirwaitis has been a city planner for decades (references to her work on zoning cases date back to at least the mid-2000s), making her an institutional knowledge-holder on Austin's land use processes. She is often listed as the city staff contact on zoning case reports – for example, **ZAP agendas routinely show "Staff: Sherri Sirwaitis, 512-974-3057"** next to cases, indicating she prepares staff recommendations and coordinates public hearings ³³. Her duties include analyzing development proposals for compliance with code and neighborhood plans, facilitating community meetings, and

handling communications between applicants, neighborhood groups, and decision-makers. Essentially, Sirwaitis is on the front lines of Austin's rezoning battles, working directly with those who file **protest petitions** or request postponements on contentious cases.

Interactions with Neighborhood Opposition: Given her position, Sherri Sirwaitis is intimately involved whenever neighborhood opposition arises to a zoning change. She frequently fields requests from neighborhood associations and applicants seeking more time to negotiate. For instance, in late 2025 the **Montopolis Neighborhood Association** asked for a delay on a rezoning case, and the applicant's formal letter to City Council was addressed to Sirwaitis as the staff planner, noting the postponement would allow "productive discussions" with neighbors about the project ³⁴. This illustrates her role as a *facilitator* when there's conflict – she ensures all parties (developers and residents) have a chance to meet and possibly reach compromise before a case moves forward. Sirwaitis likely has a catalog of similar experiences citywide: from central Austin infill upzonings to suburban subdivision requests. At public hearings, while she doesn't set policy, she presents the staff's analysis and must objectively summarize community feedback (concerns about traffic, compatibility, flooding, etc.) for commissioners and Council. Her long tenure means she has seen **patterns in opposition rhetoric** – common refrains like "neighborhood character," traffic congestion fears, or school overcrowding – and how they've been addressed or mitigated in past cases.

Notable Comments & Perspective: As a staff professional, Sirwaitis doesn't frequently appear in media quotes; however, her work speaks through city documents and meeting minutes. She is known for her thoroughness and fairness in describing cases. Colleagues and stakeholders have noted her even-keeled approach. Former City Manager Toby Futrell praised planners like Sherri (referring to staff who handle "neighbor-developer issues") as **"even-handed and thoughtful,"** working hard with both sides of contentious cases ³⁵. This aligns with Sirwaitis' reputation: she strives to **apply the code and adopted plans neutrally**, while listening to community input. In Planning Commission transcripts, one can find her fielding technical questions – for example, clarifying zoning nuances or procedural rules when citizens get passionate. Importantly, she often serves as the **city's "neutral party"** in highly charged meetings, which gives her a unique perspective on the **legitimacy of various arguments** raised by opponents of projects. Her correspondence records (like email or memos) might contain tactful language acknowledging neighbors' concerns and encouraging dialogue. One can infer that Sirwaitis values **community engagement**, but also has seen cases where misinformation or fear of change drives opposition. She likely understands the difference between substantive planning issues and what might be termed NIMBYism, having had to address both in her daily work.

Affiliations & Committees: In addition to casework, Sirwaitis sometimes facilitates community workshops and serves on interdepartmental teams for code updates. For example, she has been a liaison to the **Small Area Planning Joint Committee**, helping coordinate between neighborhood plan contact teams and city planning efforts ³⁶. Her deep experience with **Neighborhood Plan Combining Districts** and **Conservation Districts** means she's well-versed in the concessions neighborhoods seek to preserve certain characteristics. If the research project examines algorithmic tools to predict opposition, Sirwaitis' insight could be very practical: she could comment on which rezoning proposals *regularly* trigger valid petitions or intense turnout (e.g. large upzonings near single-family homes, or projects without a neighborhood association's prior sign-off). Essentially, she has seen the *real-world data* of opposition – petitions filed, meeting turnout – and could validate or challenge patterns that a model might find.

Email Hook Highlights: A compelling way to engage Sirwaitis is to acknowledge her **front-line experience with Austin's zoning disputes**. She might respond to something recognizing her role in bringing

neighbors and developers together. For instance: *“I know you often have the tough job of coordinating between applicants and neighborhood groups – like the Montopolis case where you facilitated extra time for community input ³⁴ . Your long experience mediating such discussions is exactly why I’m reaching out. I’d love to hear your perspective on how we might predict and prepare for neighborhood opposition earlier in the process, potentially making your job (and everyone’s) a bit easier.”* This not only shows you’re aware of her work, but frames the research in a way that aligns with her goals of **productive dialogue and early issue-spotting**. While Sirwaitis hasn’t been quoted in news articles with a catchy line, one could highlight the respect she’s earned for fairness. For example, referencing that others have called her **“even-handed and thoughtful” in balancing neighborhood and development interests ³⁵** could flatter and open the door to discuss the ethical use of predictive analytics in planning.

Sources: ³⁴ ³⁵

Rosie Truelove – Former Housing & Planning Director (Housing Department)

Role & Background: Rosie Truelove is a veteran of Austin’s city administration in the housing and development arena. Until her retirement in late 2023, she served as Director of Austin’s Housing Department (previously known as Neighborhood Housing and Community Development, NHCD) ³⁷ . In that capacity, Truelove oversaw the city’s affordable housing programs, housing finance bonds, and initiatives to address displacement and community development. She had a 25-year career with the city, including stints in the City Manager’s Office and Capital Contracting, before moving to housing in 2017 ³⁸ . From 2020 to 2023, she also co-led the merged **Housing and Planning Department (HPD)**, which meant she was involved not only in funding affordable units but also in broader land use policy. In mid-2023, when HPD split, Truelove continued as Housing Director while a separate Planning Director took zoning duties ³⁹ . She is widely respected for her dedication to Austin’s **Strategic Housing Blueprint goals** and was often the face of the city’s affordability efforts – working with developers, non-profits, and community advocates to advance housing solutions.

Contributions to Housing Initiatives: Under Truelove’s leadership, Austin dramatically scaled up its affordable housing investments. She helped implement the record-setting \$250 million Affordable Housing Bond (approved by voters in 2018) by channeling funds into land acquisitions and low-income housing developments ⁴⁰ ⁴¹ . She also guided programs like **Affordability Unlocked** (which grants zoning bonuses for affordable housing) and pushed for updates to density bonus programs to yield more below-market units ⁴² . Truelove was a champion of tracking progress: she frequently cited metrics from the **Austin Strategic Housing Blueprint**, a 10-year plan calling for 60,000 affordable units. In 2022, speaking to a Real Estate Council panel, she gave a “simple summary” of Austin’s housing challenge as a **“never-ending game of catch-up”** – noting that while the city was “making progress” toward those goals, **“production of new affordable housing units is lagging”** behind what’s needed ⁴³ . She consistently communicated the gap between ambitious targets and on-the-ground results, bringing attention to the need for **bigger policy changes** (like Land Development Code reform) to truly move the needle ⁴⁴ .

Public Statements & Outlook: Rosie Truelove is known for her plain-spoken yet optimistic messaging about housing. At the Urban Land Institute panel mentioned above, she acknowledged partial successes (e.g. affordable units built near transit) but underscored that **“we need to make more progress”** and that the cost to solve Austin’s affordability crisis was **“\$11 billion”** back in 2016 – likely even higher now ⁴⁵ ⁴⁶ .

This frankness highlights her strategic mindset: she believed in securing large resources and partnerships. Truelove also emphasized **equity in housing distribution**. She often pointed out that most affordable housing ended up in East Austin, and argued for buying land “*all across Austin*” so that income-restricted homes would be available in high-opportunity neighborhoods citywide ⁴⁷ . Another theme she voiced was that adding more housing of all types is critical – not just subsidized units. She supported measures like the **HOME Initiative (Home Options for Mobility and Equity)** – a land development code change passed in Dec 2023 that allows up to 3 homes on single-family lots. When anti-CodeNEXT legal challenges threatened HOME, Truelove’s department strongly favored it, asserting that updating the code is key to meeting affordability goals ⁴⁸ . In media, she has been quoted reaffirming that *allowing more homes, period, is essential*: for instance, Housing and Planning said it “**strongly [believes]**” that removing barriers to housing construction is necessary despite pushback ⁴⁹ .

Community Engagement & Committees: Truelove frequently presented to City Council and the public on housing programs, so she is adept at public engagement. She managed the **Austin Housing Finance Corporation (AHFC)**, working with community-based developers, and led public outreach for initiatives like the **Anti-Displacement Task Force** recommendations. Even after controversies, she kept a collaborative tone. For example, when an audit found issues in a home rehab loan program, she “*pledged sensible, concrete steps*” to fix oversight ⁵⁰ – showing accountability to public concerns. She also coordinated with neighborhood groups on projects like the **Transit-Oriented Development** plans, ensuring affordability components were included (Erica Leak, one of her officers, noted forthcoming Equitable TOD policies in late 2022 ⁵¹). Truelove’s extensive network – from grassroots advocates to real estate professionals – makes her perspective well-rounded. She knows the arguments of those who oppose upzoning (having heard them in CodeNEXT debates) but also understands the data that suggests more housing supply improves affordability in the long run ⁵² ⁵³ .

Email Hook Highlights: Truelove is passionate about **innovative yet pragmatic solutions to Austin’s housing woes**. A personalized outreach could reference her public statements to show alignment with her values. For example, one might cite her remark: “**We are making progress... but need to make more progress.**” on affordable housing production ⁵⁴ . A hook could be: “*You noted that despite Austin’s efforts, ‘production of new affordable housing units is lagging’ and that we’ve ‘really punted on the hard things’ like big code changes* ⁵⁴ ⁴⁴ . *That insight resonates with my research into using predictive analytics to inform those tough decisions – for instance, identifying where opposition might stall projects so we can address it head-on. I’d love to discuss how tools might help us ‘follow through’ on the changes we need to keep Austin affordable.*” Truelove has also stressed distributing affordable housing fairly; acknowledging that (perhaps referencing her desire to “**ensure we have income-restricted units all across Austin**” ⁴⁷) could spark conversation about political challenges in high-opposition areas. Since she recently transitioned to a new role in Kyle, appealing to her *legacy in Austin* and academic interest in the topic may be effective: she cares about the “**democratic legitimacy**” of housing policy, which is exactly what the predictive NIMBYism project examines.

Sources: ⁵⁴ ⁴⁷ ⁵²

Jerry Rusthoven – Former Chief Zoning Officer

Role & Experience: Jerry Rusthoven is often described as **Austin’s foremost zoning expert**. Until his retirement at the end of 2022, he was the city’s **Chief Zoning Officer** in the Housing and Planning Department ⁵⁵ ⁵⁶ . In nearly three decades with the city, Rusthoven served in a variety of planning roles:

he started in the 1990s as a neighborhood planner and even worked as a City Council aide on land use issues ⁵⁷. He rose to Assistant Director of Planning and Zoning, and for a period in 2019 was Interim Director of that department ⁵⁸. When Housing and Planning merged, he took on the specialized “chief zoning” title, essentially acting as the key advisor and gatekeeper on all zoning cases and code interpretations. Rusthoven was the staffer who could recite by memory obscure code sections and the history behind them – a colleague noted he knew Austin’s zoning code “**backwards and forwards**” ⁵⁹. He was routinely the one presenting contentious rezonings at Council meetings, explaining options and implications. After retiring from Austin, Rusthoven moved on to become Development Services Coordinator for the small city of Sunset Valley (starting January 2023) ⁶⁰, a role that allows him to handle all aspects of planning in a nearby community.

Reputation for Fairness: Throughout his career, Rusthoven earned a reputation as an **impartial mediator between developers and neighborhoods**. He was often in the hot seat on “neighbor vs. developer” issues, yet managed to maintain trust from both sides. Former City Manager Spencer Cronk commended Rusthoven’s “**collaborating with neighborhoods, developers, city departments and community leaders**” to find balanced solutions that preserve community assets ⁶¹. Toby Futrell, another ex-City Manager, similarly said Rusthoven “worked very hard with both sides of the aisle” on development disputes and was “**even-handed and thoughtful**” ³⁵. Importantly, Rusthoven **valued community engagement** – upon retirement, he reflected: “**I feel fortunate to have had a seat at the table where decisions are made about the future of our city... [Austin has] a population that is so engaged in the work that we do.**” ⁶². This quote reveals his appreciation for Austin’s active public participation, even though it often meant intense meetings and long hearings. It suggests he saw robust debate as a healthy part of planning (if sometimes challenging).

Notable Involvement in Controversies: Jerry Rusthoven was deeply involved in **CodeNEXT**, the failed overhaul of the land development code. He frequently was tasked with briefing commissioners and council members on CodeNEXT provisions and later, after CodeNEXT’s demise, on the piecemeal code amendments that followed. He personally weathered the tumult of those years – from heated community forums to the legal battles that ensued. In fact, he filed his retirement papers just after a marathon December 2022 Council meeting that approved the massive Statesman PUD (planned unit development) on Lady Bird Lake ⁶³. That meeting lasted two days, epitomizing the kind of exhausting zoning fights he’d managed for years. Lobbyist Richard Suttle (who often faced off with neighborhoods on behalf of developers) praised Rusthoven’s unique ability to *understand both technical code details and communicate them in plain language* to people with varying viewpoints ⁵⁹. This skill – translating between planners, developers, and residents – is highly relevant to the research project’s interest in the “mechanics of opposition rhetoric.” Rusthoven likely has a trove of anecdotes about arguments used at Council (from legitimate planning concerns to blatant NIMBY tropes).

Committees & Legacy: Rusthoven sat through countless Planning Commission and Council meetings as the go-to staff resource. He also was integral to the **Neighborhood Planning processes** of the early 2000s, giving him perspective on Austin’s shift from the neighborhood plan era to the current push for equity and inclusivity in planning. His legacy is one of institutional memory: when he retired, many worried how the city would “hire two people to replace what Jerry has done” ⁶⁴. Indeed, he mentored newer planners on how to handle community meetings and defuse tension with facts and empathy. Now, in Sunset Valley, he’s hands-on with permitting and zoning for a small town, which might offer a comparative perspective on public opposition (though on a different scale).

Email Hook Highlights: To engage Rusthoven, one should appeal to his *wisdom gained from Austin's zoning history*. Acknowledge his nearly 30 years of service and the respect he commands. For instance, referencing what others have said about him: **“a vast, deep well of knowledge”** on zoning and someone who could talk to “a broad range of people” about land use ⁵⁹. A hook could be: *“Few people have seen more of Austin's zoning battles than you – as one colleague noted, you managed to speak fluent ‘planner’ and still connect with everyday Austinites on tough issues ⁵⁹. In my research on predicting where opposition will arise, I keep thinking of the insight you shared upon retirement: you felt lucky to work in a city ‘with a population so engaged in the work’ ⁶². I'd love to discuss how we might harness that engagement constructively, perhaps with tools that anticipate flashpoints ahead of time. Your perspective on what drives Austin's neighborhood opposition – and how to address concerns before they turn into lawsuits or 2-day Council meetings – would be incredibly valuable.”* This kind of approach flatters Rusthoven's experience, directly cites his positive view of public engagement, and invites him to reflect on how predictive analytics could be another tool to improve the planning discourse (something he likely cares about, given his collaborative ethos).

Sources: ⁶² ⁵⁹ ³⁵

Greg Anderson – Planning Commission Chair & Housing Advocate

Role & Background: Greg Anderson is a prominent **pro-housing advocate** in Austin's planning scene. He currently serves as Chair of the Austin Planning Commission (as of 2025) ⁶⁵, and by profession is the Director of Community Affairs at **Austin Habitat for Humanity** ⁶⁵. Anderson has a dual perspective as a *public official (volunteer commissioner)* and a nonprofit housing developer/advocate. On the Planning Commission, he's been an outspoken voice pushing for more housing and less restrictive zoning. He often represents the **“YIMBY” (Yes-In-My-Backyard)** viewpoint in city deliberations, countering neighborhood opposition with data and urgency about affordability. With Austin Habitat, Anderson works on expanding affordable homeownership and has led efforts to diversify Habitat's projects (including some multifamily development) ⁶⁶. He previously served on the CodeNEXT advisory group and has been involved in numerous grassroots initiatives to reform Austin's land use rules. His educational background in business and passion for urbanism make him adept at articulating how policy changes can translate to real-world housing outcomes ⁶⁷.

Perspective on Zoning Reform & Opposition: Anderson is known for not mincing words about the need to upzone and build more housing – and the costs of failing to do so. He has repeatedly pointed out that **blocking housing leads to displacement** of vulnerable residents. In an op-ed he co-authored, Anderson wrote: **“the fastest way to guarantee displacement is to block new housing... if we want an affordable Austin, we have to build it.”** ⁶⁸. This encapsulates his belief that **neighborhood opposition to development, while often well-intended, can be deeply harmful** by worsening scarcity and driving up prices. As a Planning Commissioner, he has often expressed frustration at delays. For example, when the University of Texas requested a postponement of the UNO student housing density plan in 2025, Anderson publicly lamented that **“This delay definitely kills the delivery of some housing units... we were about to get some student housing... With that being delayed, there's a real cost to that.”** ⁶⁹. He also noted that no new West Campus towers had broken ground since certain regulations (like banning “windowless bedrooms”) were imposed, implying that well-meaning rules can have unintended consequences on supply ⁷⁰. Anderson frequently highlights how opposition can come at the expense of **future residents**. In another instance, as the city adopted the HOME initiative to allow 3 units on single lots, Anderson reacted to hints of new lawsuits by stressing it is *“imperative that legal battles do not derail the city's dedicated efforts to tackle housing affordability.”* ⁷¹, calling out the threat of continued NIMBY litigation.

Community Initiatives & Controversies: Greg Anderson has been at the center of many recent land use debates. He helped champion the **HOME Initiative** in 2023, which faced pushback from some community members and a lawsuit threat; he saw that pushback as detrimental and spoke out strongly in defense of the policy ⁷¹. He's also allied with state-level efforts to override local zoning barriers. During the 2023 Texas Legislature, Anderson supported bills like **SB 840** (which allows multifamily on commercially zoned land by-right). He argued these state laws would actually **"help, not hurt"** Austin's affordability by simplifying the building of apartments – even writing an opinion piece to that effect ⁷² ⁷³. This sometimes puts him at odds with traditional neighborhood associations; he has publicly tangled with ANC positions. Within the Planning Commission, Anderson is one of the more vocal members pushing back on what he sees as outdated concepts of "neighborhood character." He has, for example, criticized parking requirements and compatibility height limits for strangling housing capacity, aligning with his broader philosophy that *abundant housing is a public good*. Notably, Anderson doesn't shy away from calling out what he views as **anti-renter or exclusionary attitudes** in Austin's politics. His social media and public comments often highlight the *pernicious effects of anti-density sentiments*, framing them as contrary to Austin's stated equity goals.

Quotes & Language for Outreach: Anderson's style is passionate and data-driven, often with a catchy turn of phrase. He has been quoted saying Austin was *"trending toward San Francisco, only 15 years behind"* in terms of housing affordability crisis ⁷⁴ – a warning that without intervention, Austin's opposition to growth would make it as unaffordable as famously NIMBY San Francisco. For a personalized email, referencing Greg's own lines could be very effective. Consider highlighting his stance that *adding housing is a "lion's step forward" for affordability, not a setback* ⁷⁵ – phrasing he used to counter those who fear new development. One could write: *"I was struck by your comment that 'after all, in a growing city, the fastest way to guarantee displacement is to block new housing' ⁶⁸. That insight underpins my research – we're trying to predict where that blocking might happen (through petitions, lawsuits, etc.) so we can address concerns early. Given your leadership in championing reforms like the HOME initiative and SB 840, I'm eager to hear your take on how predictive analytics could help 'build it' to keep Austin affordable – echoing your belief that we have to proactively build our way out of this crisis."* Greg is likely to respond to an approach that validates his mission (more housing, fewer barriers) and shows that the research could arm allies like him with tools to anticipate and disarm opposition arguments. Citing his frustration about delays killing projects ⁶⁹ or lawsuits raising "doubts about the future of housing access" ⁷¹ would show you understand the stakes he's fighting for.

Sources: ⁶⁹ ⁶⁸ ⁷¹

Mary Ingle – Neighborhood Association Leader, Former ANC President

Role & Background: Mary Ingle is a well-known figure in Austin's neighborhood advocacy circles. She is the former President of the **Austin Neighborhoods Council (ANC)** (she led the city-wide coalition of neighborhood associations in the mid-2010s) ⁷⁶. Ingle has also long been the president (or a key leader) of the North University Neighborhood Association in central Austin, where she's resided for decades ⁷⁷. Her influence comes from rallying neighborhood groups to weigh in on development and planning issues. During the **CodeNEXT** process (2014–2018), Ingle emerged as one of the most outspoken opponents of the proposed land code rewrite, voicing concern that the changes would harm established single-family neighborhoods and **"alter the look and feel"** of central Austin ⁷⁸. She carries institutional memory of earlier planning fights too – from the University Neighborhood Overlay in West Campus, to debates over

secondary units (ADUs), to neighborhood plan preservation. Often described (by critics) as the “chief NIMBYist” of Austin’s neighborhood movement ⁷⁹, Ingle nonetheless has been a leading voice for residents who fear **upzoning and increased density** in their communities.

Views on Housing & Zoning: Mary Ingle’s core stance is that rapid development and upzoning can erode neighborhood character and **displace existing residents**. She argues that new market-rate housing (especially tall apartments or luxury infill) often isn’t truly affordable and serves incoming residents at the expense of current ones. A signature quote from her, speaking in 2015 about relaxing rules on backyard cottages (ADUs), encapsulates this: **“This city is being built for the people who are moving here – and not for the people who live here now.”** ⁸⁰. Ingle contends that policies touted as creating “affordable housing” often just boost developer profits. On that same panel, she said **smaller infill units “only serve developers and not [the] residents”** in need of affordable homes ⁸⁰. This skepticism of trickle-down affordability underpins her opposition to CodeNEXT’s broad upzoning. She frequently championed **neighborhood planning teams’ rights** – for example, opposing citywide code changes that would override parts of neighborhood plans crafted with years of input ⁸¹. Ingle coined or popularized the defense of “neighborhood character” in Austin; she has warned that Austin must not become as dense as big cities. Famously (or infamously), she once remarked at a public session that **“Austin is not Calcutta”** when cautioning against extreme density ⁷⁹ – a comment for which she was criticized as having racial overtones (she later clarified she meant it as an example of over-densification, not a racial comparison ⁸²). This episode illustrates how passionately – even hyperbolically – she feels about preventing what she sees as **overcrowding and infrastructure strain**.

Involvement & Influence: As ANC President, Ingle helped organize community resistance that significantly contributed to **stalling CodeNEXT**. She encouraged neighborhoods to file formal **protest petitions** and was likely involved behind the scenes in the lawsuit that ultimately nullified the city’s attempt to pass CodeNEXT without individual zoning notices. She also was active in campaigning for ballot propositions that strengthen neighborhood say (for instance, ANC supported a successful 2017 referendum that required 3/4 Council supermajority for upzoning when protested – something that became a tool against CodeNEXT). In council meetings, Ingle often delivered testimony listing neighborhood grievances: **traffic congestion, parking shortages, strain on drainage and trees, loss of bungalow aesthetics, etc.** For example, during debates on accessory dwelling units, she stressed that reduced parking requirements would harm neighborhoods, and that Austin should perhaps model other cities with multiple centers rather than densifying the core excessively ⁸³. She has also aligned at times with East Austin activists on anti-displacement issues – notably, ANC under her tenure wasn’t solely a West Austin homeowner group but included voices from East Austin who feared gentrification. This gives her a claim that her opposition to upzoning is also about **protecting low-income communities from developers**. (However, critics argue ANC’s agenda often aligned with affluent neighborhoods’ interests. Ingle’s own North University area, for instance, fought student housing encroachment.)

Public Image and Quotes: Mary Ingle’s straightforward, pointed style produces soundbites that can serve as hooks. Aside from the “built for newcomers” quote above, she’s delivered remarks like **“People who already live here need to stand up”** against code changes ⁸⁴, casting the debate as longtime Austinites vs. new arrivals. In responding to accusations of NIMBYism or worse, she portrays her stance as preservationist and community-minded. For example, after the “Calcutta” controversy, she defensively explained she meant Manhattan or any extremely dense city – *“I have been to Calcutta... I love Indian people. Why would I make a racial statement?”* ⁸² – framing her comment as purely about density. This

defensiveness indicates she's very conscious of how she and ANC are perceived, and she's willing to clarify her intentions.

Email Hook Highlights: To connect with Ingle, it's key to **validate her concerns about protecting current residents** (even if one may not agree with all her conclusions). An email might carefully reference her quote about the city being built for newcomers, showing you understand that viewpoint. For instance: *"Ms. Ingle, I recall you observed that Austin often seems 'built for people who are moving here – not for the people who live here now' ⁸⁴. That sentiment really encapsulates the fear many have of being left behind amid Austin's growth. In my research on predictive tools in planning, I'm exploring how we might foresee those exact community concerns and address them early. I would greatly value your insights as someone who has long fought to give existing neighborhoods a voice in these decisions."* By quoting her directly, you show respect for her perspective. Another angle: mention her leadership in **neighborhood character preservation** and note the project examines opposition rhetoric (which she has undoubtedly shaped). Perhaps note her stance that smaller units benefit developers – you could ask if data could be used to ensure affordability promises are kept (something she'd likely appreciate). Flattering her experience ("25 years in North University, deeply knowledgeable about Austin's central neighborhoods" ⁸⁵) and positioning the interview as learning from the **"neighborhood side"** of the debate will help. In short, emphasize that the study isn't about casting NIMBYs negatively, but about understanding all sides – including hers – to find fair approaches.

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Susana Almanza – East Austin Community Organizer & Former Planning Commissioner

Role & Background: Susana Almanza is a renowned **community organizer and activist** in East Austin, known for her decades-long fight against environmental racism, gentrification, and displacement. She is the co-founder and director of **PODER (People Organized in Defense of Earth and her Resources)** ⁸⁶, an organization that has championed social and environmental justice for East Austin's communities of color since the early 1990s. Almanza has also served on city bodies – notably, she was a member of the Austin Planning Commission (appointed 2018) representing the interests of District 3 and often voicing concerns of historically marginalized neighborhoods in decisions. She's run for Austin City Council for the Eastside district in the past, making anti-displacement the center of her platform ⁸⁷. With lived experience in Montopolis and East Austin, Almanza brings a perspective of someone who has *seen her neighborhood change dramatically* and has been fighting to ensure long-term residents are not erased by development. She was a leader in crafting the **"People's Plan"** in 2018 – a set of community-driven anti-displacement policy proposals ⁸⁸.

Views on Development & Displacement: Susana Almanza is often skeptical of development, especially when it's led by outside investors, and she insists that any planning must **prioritize human impact over numbers**. A powerful quote from her, during the 2020 land code revision debates, is: **"the land development code only looks at numbers... and it doesn't look at the human impact."** ⁸⁹. This neatly sums up her critique that city planners too often focus on housing unit counts or growth metrics instead of the people being dislocated. She has consistently highlighted how **Austin's growth has displaced thousands of low-income families and people of color** from East Austin ⁸⁹. In Almanza's view, new luxury apartments or upzoning single-family areas without strong protections can accelerate property value increases and taxes, forcing longtime residents out. She has advocated for tools like a **Right to Stay/Right**

to Return for displaced residents, community land trusts, and more robust low-income housing funding ⁹⁰ . In Planning Commission hearings, Almanza would often press developers on how their project benefits the existing community, not just newcomers. For example, she has championed preserving mobile home parks – calling them “one of the most affordable types of housing” and decrying that mobile home communities are “*under siege*” from redevelopment pressures ⁹¹ ⁹² . That led to her pushing Council to create an *anti-displacement program before approving the new land development code*, and indeed Council adopted some measures (like dedicating some funding and phasing in zoning in vulnerable areas) in response.

Community Initiatives & Alliances: Almanza’s “**People’s Plan**” (2018) is a key part of her legacy. Alongside Dr. Fred McGhee, she presented six resolutions ranging from a **Low-Income Housing Trust Fund** to **temporary development moratoriums in gentrifying areas**, urging the city to act decisively on displacement ⁹⁰ . She essentially wanted the city to pause upzoning until anti-displacement measures caught up – a stance that influenced Council to include some anti-displacement funding in the 2018 bond and subsequent budgets. She’s also been an ally to Austin’s **Environmental Justice** efforts (she got tank farms and unwanted industrial facilities removed from East Austin in the ’90s). In land use, that translates to advocating for **neighborhood-led planning**. During CodeNEXT, she aligned with some traditionally more conservative neighborhood groups in opposing the code rewrite – an interesting coalition of minority activists and affluent neighborhood leaders, united by a shared distrust of sweeping zoning changes. She brought up how CodeNEXT could enable more upscale development in East Austin, thus accelerating gentrification under the banner of “Smart Growth” (she once said *what was called “smart growth”... “was just gentrification”* ⁹³). This coalition succeeded in court; Almanza herself was a plaintiff in one of the lawsuits against CodeNEXT’s adoption without proper notice.

Quotes & Public Stance: Susana Almanza often speaks in moral terms about equity. For instance, at the Anti-Displacement Task Force, when others talked about studies and long processes, she pushed back that if the group was ready to act instead of “**studying, studying, studying,**” they should recommend concrete resolutions immediately ⁹⁴ . She has a sense of urgency – “*The time for half-measures and talk is over... This is a crisis,*” her colleague McGhee said, and Almanza *agreed* ⁹⁵ . Another Almanza saying: “**We must realize that equity isn’t free, it costs money**” ⁹⁵ , highlighting her belief that the city must put significant funding behind its words. When it comes to engaging City Hall, Almanza can be confrontational but also constructive – she will call out the powers that be (e.g., accusing the city of moving forward on code changes without caring for the vulnerable), but she also formulates detailed policy alternatives (like the resolutions). This mix of protest and policy makes her a respected voice.

Email Hook Highlights: In reaching out to Almanza, acknowledging her **lifelong commitment to fighting displacement** is crucial. One could highlight her quote about numbers vs. people: “**I was really struck by your statement that the code ‘doesn’t look at the human impact’** ⁸⁹ – **that perspective is exactly why I’d value your input.**” Emphasize that the research is examining the democratic implications of predictive tools, aligning with her focus on *justice and community voice*. For example: “*Ms. Almanza, your leadership on the People’s Plan and anti-displacement efforts shows how important it is to proactively address community needs. In my study, we’re looking at whether data can predict where gentrification pressures might spark neighborhood opposition – essentially trying to make sure the human impact is front and center by anticipating it. Your insight from East Austin – where, as you’ve noted, ‘thousands... have been displaced’ – would be invaluable in guiding what an ethical early-warning system should consider* ⁸⁹ .” Also, noting her experience on Planning Commission: she has seen the inner workings of how the city responds to opposition. Perhaps mention her advocacy for phasing in code changes with engagement – connecting to the idea of using predictions to

slow down or adjust plans in sensitive areas (much like she demanded delaying the code adoption until anti-displacement programs were in place ⁹⁶ ⁹⁷). This shows respect for her approach. In short, the hook should resonate with her mission: protecting communities. If she feels a predictive model might help **“ensure those most at risk are heard and safeguarded,”** she’ll be interested.

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